like arrangement, especially in respect to South Asia. This approach was to return under Obama, not coincidentally with the same set of American officials. Ironically, China in the 1960s used to complain about this very kind of big power condominium.

The Chinese interest in South Asia, as a whole, also expanded during this period, as did its ties with Myanmar. Anti-piracy patrols after 2008 gave it a good reason to start operating in the Indian Ocean. The establishment of ports in Pakistan and Sri Lanka had their own resonance. All the while, its higher economic growth widened the power differential with a neighbour whose commitment to reform was more half-hearted.

The year 2009 is the turning point in China's current rise. The combination of a global financial crisis, a change in the US Administration, and the consequences of the Iraq war now no longer made it necessary to hide its light. To the extent it did till 2012, this was the caution of old habits and experiences. Coming in to Beijing at that very time as Ambassador, I had a ringside view of the vigorous expression of this newfound confidence. It was visible in policy, articulation and political choreography. All nations were impacted, however differently. The ASEAN witnessed moves on the South China Sea and an accompanying change in attitude to regional structures. With Japan, there was a greater focus on its territorial dispute. The US too was tested on a range of security and economic issues. The equation with Russia shifted in China's favour and the Eurozone crisis gave an easy entry into a difficult market. With India, this period saw both bilateral challenges despite multilateral cooperation. Stapled visas and border intrusions dominated news, even as the two continued to make common cause in many global councils. With the 18th Party Congress, India's ties, like that of the rest of the world, entered a new era.

When relations were normalized by Prime Minister Indira Gandhi in 1976, the ties naturally had little economic content. Even when Rajiv Gandhi visited China a decade later, its economic content was minuscule. China's own energies were directed largely at the developed economies from whom it imported capital and technology, obtaining increasing market access in return. But as China's economy grew and India's opened up, opportunities for trade began to be more aggressively exploited. Trade figures tell their